Last Requests

By Giles Smith

COOK: **(Pg 31-43)** Pork chop – nice and thick – with sprouts, a carrot-and-swede mix, mashed potatoes and gravy. Now, that's a proper meal. And after, fruit pie and custard or cream. A proper, home-backed pie, mind you – none of your tins and packets. Proper, wholesome food. But a lot of them, these days, they don't want that. It's all burgers and fries. Milkshakes, some of them. Well, that's not a proper meal is it? Not what I call a proper, sit-down meal. With my three, every night, there was meat and vegetables and a pie afterwards, never fail. Always. Not like the kids all picky and refusing to eat. I'd crack the whip. No getting down until that bowl's clean. Come on: chop chop, eat up, or you'll waste away.

INTRODUCTION

According to Pew Research.org, use of the death penalty has gradually declined in the United States in recent decades. But, while state-level executions have decreased, the federal government put more prisoners to death (a total of 87) under President Donald Trump than at any point since the U.S. Supreme Court reinstated capital punishment in 1976. As of September 1, 2021, five executions by lethal injection have taken place this year in the US.

Study media reports of executions, recent or decades-old, and you'll probably find mention of the prisoner's last meal. Although the custom has a rich and controversial history, last meals evoke a morbid curiosity and leave many people wondering, "What would I choose as my final meal?"

This prison cook has quite a lot to say about the prisoners' Last Requests by Giles Smith

COOK: Steak – that's popular. Quite a few of them ask for steak, and when the do, I try to get a nice one. I do a good steak. The problem with steak is, it's quite a long way from the kitchen to the Row. You've got to go out of the canteen block then across "Y" yard and up three flights. It can take a few minutes what with the security grilles. Really, with a steak, that's not the best thing. A steak should be out of the frying pan and onto the plate and then straight into your mouth, all hot and melty. You don't want to wait

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around for a steak. They might be better off with a stew or a pie. Something which keeps its heat. I don't think any of them think about that – though why should they? It's not like they haven't got plenty on their minds already, my God.

I've been doing it for two and a bit years now, and I suppose you get into something like a routine. There was all sorts of fuss when they brought it back. People say, we didn't used to need it. But you'd have to say it was a more innocent world then. There wasn't the terrorism, for one thing. Or there was, but not nearly so much of it. And you never heard about people having guns, the way you do now. And all the business with the children, when people got very worked up about. I don't know why, as time goes by there just seems to be more wickedness generally. Like the one they sent off last night. Nineteen years old. Climbed a tree by a playground in a park and started firing. Eleven little ones he killed, and three mothers. They asked him why and he said, "I wanted to see them scared." Well, what are you going to do with someone like that? No, on the whole, I think they had to bring it back.

Some people think they don't deserve anything. Jean from next door, she's said to me before, "I don't know how you can bring yourself. Cooking a special tea for someone who's evil." And I know what she means, except I don't really see it like that. I know the kind they get up there. They've done awful things, wicked things, it's unimaginable what they've done, some of them. But even so, I think there's human standards and you've got to treat them right. You've got to remember, they've been up there for months [years], some of them – sitting around, thinking about what's coming. It's a difficult time for them. And they don't get any special treatment up there, day to day, far from it, just the same food as the rest which, between you and me . . . I mean, we do our best, but the budget's tight and anyway you're cooking for nineteen hundred. There's not exactly going to be the personal touch, is there?

I don't know what it must be like, to know you're going to die. We know they've done wrong and we know we can't forgive them, but at least we can give them their dignity at

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the end. Well, that's how I see it. I said to Jean, "You'd want the same if it was you, Jean."

They can have what they like, within reason, up to a maximum of three courses, with coffee or tea and a piece of confectionery if they want it. No alcohol, for obvious reasons. You'll get the jokers, like the one who said he wanted a whole roast pig with an apple in its mouth. Or the governor's head, one of them said he wanted. The boy in the tree wanted cauliflower cheese. Which, to be honest, I think of more as a snack than a proper supper.

There's some that are so negative, I don't pretend to understand. "20 Marlboro Lights, one packet of chewing gum." A shame really, when you think what he could have had. But there's quite a number, in actual fact, who only want cigarettes. Or bowls of cereal, even. It's as if they've already given up, in a way. And you wouldn't believe the writing on some of those forms. It's good the wardens go through it with them first, because some of them, frankly, I wouldn't be able to read. Big letters and small letters all jumbled. And as for spelling . . . it's all they can do, some of them, to write their names.

I think the fact you could have anything kind of paralyses them in a way. It's almost as if they'd be better off with a menu, a range of options, so they could choose. There was one the other week who just wanted a sandwich. They'd gone up at midday to collect the form and he was just sitting there, hadn't written anything. He was this middle-aged man who'd killed his children, four of them, at breakfast one morning, with a rifle – for no real reason, apparently. He just got angry and that was that, and the next thing he was phoning the police and asking them to come and get him. Just a sandwich. Sad, really, but I think it's true of a lot of them on the Row that they don't really know their own minds by the end. I made him a cheese and pickle one, because nobody ever objects to that.

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I've never met any of the ones I've done the meal for. They don't let them in the canteen area, so I never set eyes on them. I suppose I am curious sometimes, to know what they're like. The one who killed his children. I'd have like to try and tempt him into something more than a sandwich. Sometimes the wardens will pass something on; "He looked happy with that. "

The meal goes up at 8:00 and the executions are directly after midnight. There's some legal reason for that, I think. But that's four hours between the meal and the end of it and I often wonder if they get puckish again. Every now and again, you'll send the meal up and they'll eat it, and then the phone call comes through from the judge and they get a reprieve. All very dramatic. Well, good for them. But often it's only temporary and, a month later, you're cooking the same meal for them all over again. There's one up there now who's had his last meal five times.

I can be away by 8:30, which is plenty of time for the bus. There's often a crowd outside when I leave. People come to the gates when there's an execution. There's a man with a big black parka. He's always there. I don't know why. It's not like there's anything to see. There isn't even a clock that chimes. It just gets to be after midnight, and at that point they all go away again. So the wardens tell me. Sometimes, when I leave, there might be some banners and there might be a bit of shouting going on. But more often than not they're just standing there quietly, like they're waiting for something, I've no idea what.

Last night was odd, though. I hadn't quite managed to get the monthly freezer check done during the day, so after they'd taken up the cauliflower cheese for the boy in the tree, I finished the job off. I'd got my coat on when Dave came back with the tray. [He] didn't say anything, just put it down and turned away and I got a good look then and I wished I hadn't because, do you know what, he hadn't touched it.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Giles Smith
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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

More data about the death penalty in the US can be found here
https://documents.deathpenaltyinfo.org/pdf/FactSheet.pdf

Also of interest:
The Serial Killer Cookbook by Ashley Lecker
ISBN: 978-1646040230
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